

"In India, there's lack of appreciation of the need to cross-examine data, the responsibility of a statistician."

THE PLAN MAN

His lasting contributions were the setting up of large-scale surveys, the application of statistical theory to a variety of Indian problems and the creation of institutions within which such work could be continued

P.C. Mahalanobis

Statistician 1893-1972

■ By Rohini Somanathan

Prasanta Chandra Mahalanobis is popularly known among Indians for his draft of the Second Five Year Plan which he submitted to the National Development Council in 1955. Soon after Independence, he was appointed the statistical advisor to the newly-formed Cabinet and the Plan was formulated to meet the state's principal objective of eliminating unemployment through rapidly rising industrial production. Based on a growth model for the Indian economy—and his observation that the production of steel, more than any other single factor, explained the differences in incomes across countries—Mahalanobis recommended the large investments in heavy industry that created the steel cities of central and eastern India.

As is often the case, the greatest achievements of creative minds are not the most widely known, and this was true for Mahalanobis. He was not trained as an economist and his approach to planning was largely a reflection of the prevailing views of economic development during his time. Growth models of the '30s and '40s assumed labour surplus economies that were constrained by the speed at which they could create machines and factories for the unem-

